staff persuaded their own womenfolk to opt for such services, she pointed out.

One can imagine, when even with such a benevolent leadership in Tihar, old habits were taking time to die out, what must have been the condition when the earlier leadership had left the entire system to run by itself.

A foreign correspondent once rang up Kiran at home to ask her about the inordinately long periods of incarceration of foreign nationals booked under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and awaiting trial. She told him that it was not in her hands to decide the period for which they languished in jail, but, yes, she could do a lot about the quality of the time they spent there. Certain special privileges were granted to them by way of letting them stay together, giving them a slightly modified menu, permitting books in various languages to pursue foreign language courses, allowing them to play guitars and other facilities. This sort of treatment was being accorded because this group of inmates had their own distinct cultural identities (different from the Indian ethos) and, in this way, their trauma was reduced. Of course, she explained, the prison was a microcosm of the outside world and therefore it had to be reflective of the general and average lifestyle of India and so it would be absurd to expect 'star' treatment.

Yes, the jail is indeed a microcosm of the India that lives outside it. And outside the condition of a majority of women is pathetic. They have virtually no rights and are merely treated as barely tolerable property to be passed from father, to husband, to son. At any of these stages she has only to prove herself to be interfering or burdensome and her life becomes a veritable hell. Those unfortunate women who find their way to prison are, by and large, uneducated, submissive and apathetic to their accepted lot in life. In prison they do not have the foggiest notion of the technicalities of legal or prison rights, rules of remission parole or premature release. Lawyers are quick to take them on as clients and hence the latter leave matters in the former's hands. Intermittently, lawyers fleece them for money, but even then they languish for years in prison without even once seeing the inside of a court.

For the prison staff such women become grist for their libidinous mill. The apathy of the outside world is turned to cruelty here. The more mental torment suffered by the women, the more pliable they become in the jail staff's hands. Physical punishments are awarded not as corrective measures but more to satisfy sadistic desires that find an unobstructed vent in the confines of the prison walls. And rape becomes a veritable right.

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In Tihar, because of overcrowding, women convicts, undertrials, prostitutes and even hardened criminals were all kept together. The general barracks contained four times their sanctioned capacity and prisoners who had been here longer managed to curry favour with the staff so as to rule the roost. Young undertrials, expecting to be here for only a few days, weeks or months became their prime targets. The latter were quickly enslaved and made to perform chores like sweeping and washing clothes and, through persistent pressure, converted to lesbianism.

Even when taken to hospitals the women inmates were not given any preferential treatment. There would be no segregation from male prisoners. Most of the time, they would be examined by male doctors.

If there was a hell on earth for women, this was it.

The levels of corruption to which the jail staff members had reduced themselves and the degradation to which the inmates were driven have been elucidated by the words of an ex-superintendent of the jail: